

Tying the Financial Knot

Once you've decided to tie the knot, discussions about money shouldn't be far behind. When you get married, you take on all his or her financial baggage as well. You need to know just how heavy that baggage is.

Talking about Money

You may want to start out by first discussing how your parents handled money and how you feel about its role in your life. For some people, money symbolizes love or security; for others, it symbolizes power or control. It can be spent freely or hoarded and saved. Explore your feelings about money together.

After you've had a few initial discussions about money in general, initiate a discussion about your respective financial situations. Figure out whether either of you have any of the following:

- Large debts
- Student loans
- Credit card debt
- Child support or alimony obligations
- A bad credit record
- Past bankruptcy
- Investments
- An inheritance
- A trust fund

Get copies of your credit reports and go over them together. If your spouse-to-be won't talk about money, consider counseling. How can you work toward common goals if one of you can't or won't talk about money?

It's important to realize that each of you will probably have goals that the other doesn't share. Acknowledge that they're important too, and try to find a way to work toward these individual goals as well as those you have in common.